WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

NIGERIA

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Lagos	Commercial and financial capital and West Africa's largest consumer market; home to the Nigerian Exchange and most corporate headquarters	Financial services, fintech, consumer goods, real estate
Lekki corridor (Lagos)	Site of the Lekki Deep Sea Port and the Dangote refinery, now processing around 700,000 barrels a day, anchoring a fast-growing industrial cluster	Refining, petrochemicals, port logistics, manufacturing
Abuja (FCT)	Federal capital; seat of the Presidency, regulators and the Nigerian Investment Promotion Commission	Government services, construction, real estate
Niger Delta (Rivers, Delta, Bayelsa)	Core oil and gas production region, with Port Harcourt as its commercial hub; national crude output averaged 1.72 million barrels a day in Q2 2026	Upstream oil and gas, gas processing, oilfield services
Kano and the north	Historic trading hub for northern Nigeria and the Sahel, with a large agricultural hinterland	Agro-processing, trade, light manufacturing
Ogun and the South-West belt	Manufacturing belt adjoining Lagos with access to its ports and consumer base	Manufacturing, building materials, logistics
Free trade zones (NEPZA)	Nationwide network of free zones offering tax and customs incentives for export-oriented and industrial projects	Manufacturing, logistics, processing for export

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Nigerian Investment Promotion Commission (NIPC), the federal investment promotion agency, whose Act guarantees foreign investors the right to repatriate capital and profits
- Certificate of Capital Importation (CCI), issued by an authorised dealer bank on behalf of the Central Bank within 24 hours of an inflow, the key document for repatriating dividends, profits and capital
- Four Tax Reform Acts signed in June 2025, consolidating the tax system, creating the Nigeria Revenue Service and exempting small companies with turnover up to N100 million
- Free trade zones licensed by the Nigeria Export Processing Zones Authority (NEPZA), offering tax and customs incentives for qualifying projects
- Central Bank of Nigeria oversight of a unified, market-determined foreign-exchange market (NFEM), with the naira stable near N1,333 to the dollar in October 2026

- Domestic capital market regulated by the Securities and Exchange Commission, which in 2026 hosted the Dangote refinery IPO seeking about N2.15 trillion
- Upstream licensing through the Nigerian Upstream Petroleum Regulatory Commission (NUPRC) and state electricity markets enabled by the Electricity Act 2023

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Nigeria in October 2026 is Africa's most populous market and one of its clearest reform stories. GDP growth rose to 4.43% in Q2 2026, inflation eased for a fourth consecutive month to 14.63% in September, and in September the Central Bank of Nigeria reset its policy rate 350 basis points lower to 23%. Gross external reserves stood at $55.07 billion in early October, which the central bank describes as the highest in more than 18 years, the current-account surplus reached $7.54 billion in Q2, and the naira has been stable in the unified foreign-exchange market. Investor confidence is visible: capital inflows rose 83.8% to $10.37 billion in Q1 2026, Nigeria exited the FATF grey list in October 2025, and S&P upgraded the sovereign to B in May 2026. Four Tax Reform Acts signed in 2025 and the Electricity Act 2023 are steadily modernising the investment framework.

Nigeria's main structural challenge is converting macroeconomic stabilisation into sustained, broad-based direct investment: portfolio flows made up 95% of Q1 2026 inflows, with FDI at 1.3%, and crude oil still accounts for close to half of goods exports. Progress on both fronts is tangible. Crude output averaged 1.72 million barrels a day in Q2 2026, up from 1.55 million in Q1. The Dangote refinery has lifted throughput to around 700,000 barrels a day, launched a domestic IPO and plans a $14.3 billion expansion to 1.4 million barrels a day by 2029, turning Nigeria into a regional refining hub. A goods trade surplus of about N12.6 trillion in Q2 2026 and strong reserves give the economy a solid buffer, while state electricity markets and free zones are opening opportunities for direct investors in energy, manufacturing and logistics.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Foreign-exchange history	Past currency shortages and devaluations remain a reference point for investors, although FX unification and reserves above $55 billion have restored liquidity and stability	Register inflows with a Certificate of Capital Importation, apply standard hedging and structure for repatriation through licensed banks
Inflation and cost of capital	Inflation has fallen to 14.63% and the policy rate to 23%, but local borrowing costs remain high by international standards and the central bank says policy will stay restrictive as needed	Use DFI and offshore financing where possible; continued disinflation creates room for local funding costs to ease over time
Security in parts of the country	Security conditions vary by region, and pipeline vandalism has historically affected oil output, which rose to 1.72 million barrels a day in Q2 2026	Commission location-specific security assessments and focus initial investment on Lagos, Abuja and established industrial corridors
Electricity supply	Grid supply remains uneven, adding to operating costs, but the Electricity Act 2023 has enabled states to create their own electricity markets	Plan for embedded or captive power; state markets create opportunities for generation and distribution investors
Public debt and fiscal pressures	Public debt rose to N166.79 trillion (about $121 billion) in Q2 2026, keeping debt service a fiscal priority	Tax reforms and higher oil revenue remittances are supporting revenue; monitor fiscal developments and favour projects with hard-currency or export earnings
Election cycle	General elections are due in 2027, and the central bank is preparing for election-related shifts in liquidity and currency demand	Build election-period timing into transaction planning; Nigeria has held regular elections with orderly transfers of power since 1999
Regulatory complexity	Overlapping federal and state requirements can lengthen approvals, although the tax reforms are simplifying the framework	Engage NIPC early, retain experienced local counsel and use free zone structures where they fit the project

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Nigeria's risk profile has improved markedly since 2023, reflecting a coherent reform programme of exchange-rate unification, monetary tightening followed by a rate reset, tax modernisation and power-sector decentralisation. Reserves above $55 billion, falling inflation, a current-account surplus, the exit from the FATF grey list and S&P's upgrade to B all point to a more predictable operating environment. The main considerations for investors are the cost of local capital, uneven power supply, regional security conditions and the run-up to the 2027 elections; each is manageable with sound structuring, careful site selection and appropriate financing. Investors who register capital correctly, hedge currency exposure and focus on established corridors are well placed to benefit from the scale of Nigeria's market as the reform dividend broadens.

MARKET ACCESS

Nigeria is a member of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), giving preferential access to West African regional markets, and is a party to the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA). It has been a WTO member since 1995. Crude oil accounted for 47.8% of goods exports in Q2 2026, with non-crude exports, including refined products from the Dangote refinery, now the larger share and reshaping regional fuel supply. Total goods trade reached N41.44 trillion in Q2 2026, up 5.6% year on year, with a surplus of about N12.6 trillion. The UK–Nigeria Enhanced Trade and Investment Partnership held its inaugural ministerial dialogue in March 2026, and the UK was the largest source of capital inflows in Q1 2026, while the Lagos ports, led by the deep-water Lekki port, give Nigeria a growing role as a regional logistics gateway.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
The Presidency (President Bola Ahmed Tinubu)	Drives the reform programme on FX unification, tax reform and oil-sector recovery	Primary reference point for Nigeria's strategic and economic direction
Nigerian Investment Promotion Commission (NIPC)	Federal investment promotion agency and first point of contact for foreign investors	Standard entry point for registration, incentives and facilitation
Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN)	Sets monetary policy and manages the unified FX market and external reserves	Key counterpart on currency, repatriation and banking matters
Federal Ministry of Finance	Leads fiscal policy and debt management, and coordinates with the central bank under a fiscal-monetary MoU	Relevant for fiscal outlook, incentives and public-private partnerships
NNPC Limited and NUPRC	National oil company and upstream regulator, central to licensing and to lifting crude output beyond 1.72 million barrels a day	Essential counterparts for any oil and gas engagement
Securities and Exchange Commission and Nigerian Exchange	Regulate and operate the capital market, the main channel for portfolio inflows	Relevant for listings, including the Dangote refinery IPO, and portfolio investment
Nigeria Export Processing Zones Authority (NEPZA)	Licenses and regulates free trade zones and their incentive regime	Route to tax and customs incentives for export-oriented projects

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The UK–Nigeria Enhanced Trade and Investment Partnership provides a structured government-to-government channel, with its inaugural ministerial dialogue held in March 2026, and the Nigerian-British Chamber of Commerce and the American Chamber of Commerce in Nigeria are the leading bilateral business bodies. The Nigerian Economic Summit Group convenes the annual Nigerian Economic Summit, the main public-private policy forum. NIPC runs investor outreach and aftercare, and state governments, particularly Lagos, increasingly hold their own investment events. The World Bank, the International Finance Corporation and the African Development Bank are active in power, infrastructure and private-sector development, and large international energy companies and banks with long-standing Nigerian operations are useful sources of practical intelligence.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Nigeria suits investors seeking scale and long-term growth in Africa's largest consumer market: consumer-goods, retail and fintech investors drawn by a young, urbanising population; energy investors in midstream gas, refining and petrochemicals building on the Dangote refinery and rising upstream output; power investors able to work with the new state electricity markets; and manufacturing and logistics investors using free zones and the Lekki port corridor to serve Nigeria and West Africa. Portfolio and capital-markets investors benefit from FX reform, record reserves and lower policy rates, while patient, well-structured direct investors are best placed to capture the broader reform dividend.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage NIPC and confirm entry structure
Open dialogue with the Nigerian Investment Promotion Commission on registration, sector incentives and any free zone options for the project.

STEP 2: Register capital and plan repatriation from day one
Bring funds in through a licensed bank and obtain a Certificate of Capital Importation to secure the right to repatriate dividends and capital.

STEP 3: Review the Tax Reform Acts and incentive regime
Take local tax and legal advice on the four 2025 Tax Reform Acts, including the new development levy and small-company exemptions, to optimise structuring.

STEP 4: Select locations with security and power in mind
Prioritise Lagos, Abuja and established industrial corridors, and plan captive or state-market power supply for operations.

STEP 5: Time transactions around the 2027 election cycle
Build the 2027 election period into deal timetables and track central bank policy, as continued disinflation could lower local funding costs.